THE OTTOMAN EMPIRE

The great period of Ottoman expansion was in the reigns of Selim the Grim (1512–20) and Suleiman the Magnificent (1520–66). The former conquered Egypt and much of the Middle East, the latter extended Ottoman rule far into southeastern Europe and North Africa. During this time the Ottomans also became the dominant naval power in the eastern Mediterranean and threatened to do the same in the western half.

KEY

- Ottoman Empire 1512
- Ottoman conquests by 1639
- Austrian Habsburg possessions
- Spanish Habsburg possessions
- Frontiers 1600
- Holy Roman Empire
- Ottoman victory
- Ottoman defeat



straight ahead—aimed by pointing the galley at the target—augmented by swivel guns to rake the enemy decks. Other Christian vessels might carry a much heavier weight of armament. Large galeasses—converted merchant ships—were even capable of firing broadsides. Christian fighting men often wore armor and fired arquebuses instead of crossbows, while the Muslims remained lightly clad and equipped with traditional missile weapons. An Ottoman fleet often had the advantage of superior maneuverability, however. In the course of the 16th century most Christian states resorted to *a scaloccio* rowing—very large oars, each pulled by four, five, or even more rowers. These were operated mostly by slaves and criminals condemned to the galleys. Venice alone maintained a predominance of free oarsmen. The *a scaloccio* system militated against deft and skilful maneuver, as did the increasing size of galleys viewed as gun platforms. Christian fleets typically advanced in line abreast to defend their flanks and maximize forward fire. Handled aggressively, Ottoman galleys could break up the Christian line and win in a pell-mell battle.

AFTER LEPANTO

Lepanto, the last major battle in which galleys overwhelmingly predominated, was a major Ottoman defeat. But it was far from ending Ottoman naval efforts, because the empire had the resources to build a new fleet to replace the one it had lost. The Ottomans were long able to hold their own against Christians in the eastern Mediterranean, beating Venice in a war for control of Crete in the mid-17th century and besting a combined Christian fleet at Matapan in 1717. Meanwhile, the Barbary corsairs extended their activities into the Atlantic, their nifty xebecs even raiding the coasts of the British Isles—almost the entire population of the Irish village of Baltimore was carried off by the North African raiders in 1631. The depredations of the Barbary pirates continued largely unchecked until the early years of the 19th century.



The Crescent and the Cross
In this clash of galleys of the Lepanto era, the Christians fire their foredeck cannons on the Ottoman foe.